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Arthur Baron

Trombonist Art Baron was born in Bridgeport, Connecticut on January 5, 1950. His versatility has enabled him to perform with a long list of jazz and popular artists including Stevie Wonder, Frank Wess, Bruce Springsteen and the Duke Ellington Orchestra. His composition "Urban Kaleidoscope" was premiered by the Lincoln Center Jazz Orchestra in 1995.

Art was interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 13, 2008 before a concert with the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, on campus. I'm very pleased to have multi-instrumentalist Art Baron with me today. I was reading through your resume trying to find out a name of someone you haven't played with.

AB: I've been a very lucky guy.

MR: Yeah. Easier to find out who you haven't — when you were 17 let's say, did you have those kinds of aspirations, to just be —

AB: Since I was like a senior or a junior in high school. You know I was having so much fun in music. I did everything I could. Like I was in high school, and there was a local group of musicians, The Doctor's Band, and they met like once every two weeks or so. Dentists, lawyers, some of them had gone out with territory bands, and some of them were great. There was a dentist there that sounded like Marshall Royal on lead alto. His name was Dr. Culshack. He laid that down man. And these guys took me in, and I just had the greatest time. And I was a rebel. I was like a middle child and like I would go to these rehearsals and they'd have a jam session sometimes afterwards and I got home like at twelve, when they said be home at eleven, so they took the car away for a week or two. I'd go out and do it again. I kept just doing it. I think they finally gave up on me. But it was just what I loved doing, you know. When I was a kid, in the fifth or sixth grade, I was pretty good in most subjects, at that time anyway. But I didn't have that identity of like sports or this or that. But I went through my first year of playing music, and I almost quit trombone. And the second year all of a sudden I just took to it, and I just boom. You know I was practicing hours a day, and loving it. I did everything I could musical.

MR: Were you fortunate to have a good teacher in the public school?

AB: Yeah. I'm trying to think. I mean he was like, sorry Mr. Fink, I mean he was cool, he was great. I mean he was a taskmaster. I'll never forget he had this little like pencil moustache

pencil. He was really on it. And yeah, he was a taskmaster. He had my mother and father sign the practice sheet and if I didn't practice they wouldn't sign it so he'd know. So it's a long story. You want to hear that story?

MR: Well go ahead, because I have my own variation.

AB: Well this is fifth grade, and I'm not really serious about it. I had it, and they give you a school instrument. So sometimes I practiced, sometimes I didn't, and I tried to get my mother to sign one of those weeks where I didn't and she said, "I'm not going to sign this." So I said, "I'm going to get in a heap of trouble, come on." And this was probably halfway through the year, so she said, "No, deal with it." So I said, "Well then I quit." And she said, "You can't quit." And I said, "Why not?" She said "you deprived someone else from having that trombone so you have to use it the rest of the year and then if you want to quit you can quit." So I was like, "Awww." So I continued on and I started practicing more and more, and Mr. Fink at the end of the year they let me take the horn home, I was totally into it by then. And Mr. Fink, he said something to me and I went home and my mother was surprised to see the trombone, and I said, "He said I could have it all summer and that I could play it and use it." And I said something, I'm paraphrasing or whatever, he said to me, "And Mr. Fink said I might be what you call gifted." And my mother said she was just, like had a whole batch of tears from laughing. And I still tell that story when she is on one of my gigs. So I say, "It's all your fault, I could have been a lawyer — I'm Jewish, I could have been a doctor, I could have all this money." And then in high school I just did everything musical, I would play a washtub bass in a jug band, you know, so my ears opened up early, which is great. I wasn't just jazz, just jazz, or just one kind of jazz. So I ended up listening to all kinds of stuff and playing in this jug band, we'd do gigs. I remember doing gigs in high school with a local society band, one of the better ones, in New Haven, Connecticut, about a half hour from where I lived. A guy named Pat Dorn. You know it's funny, I'd always, the joke was I always had a thirty dollar check in my pocket, which was a lot of money back then, or else I didn't have money. You know like we'd go to a restaurant and I'd say, "I only have this thirty dollar check."

MR: Do you remember what the first paying gig you ever had was?

AB: Absolutely. I don't remember the name of the group but it was — I wish I could remember the guy's name — an accordion player playing stuff like "Al Di La" a drummer, and I remember these faces, it was a guitar player and myself, oh and a baritone sax player later became a surgeon, Carl Nemenioti or something. These names will come later but I mean we played at the Sub Alpino Club and we each made fifteen dollars. And we were playing things like "Al Di La," "Westminster [sic] Cathedral," I

know the forms or anything like that. Then we went out to a diner afterwards and spent all the money.

MR: Right. But you know, fifteen dollars for having a good time playing music.

AB: That's why the club owners don't like paying us, because that's only one of two gigs in the world where you smile while you're doing it.

MR: What about — you and I are the same age actually I noticed—

AB: You're old enough to be my brother.

MR: There you go. But I remember being turned on to pop music, like Little Eva and "The Locomotion" and that kind of stuff that was on AM radio. Did that stuff make an impression on you?

AB: Some of the pop stuff I discovered later It wasn't like I was against it, and I can't remember what instrument — and of course the Beatles were all around. I didn't get the Beatles as much as I did later. But I don't know, that's a good question, because I can't quite remember what really turned me on back then. I mean we listened to as much jazz as we could. But wide open. Like for instance, we lived in Fairfield, Connecticut, that's where I lived, who's we, I don't — and there was a radio station in Baltimore — I can hardly remember the name now, but they had "The Harley Show," this guy that made the Harley Sandwich Shop, he made these big subs and stuff. And he had this great jazz show. And in the summer, the AM signal skips. So you'd get it from a pretty far distance like that. And I used to get upstairs like at one in the morning with my little transistor radio. It was "The Harley Show" man. And "Things Ain't What They Used to Be", I can't remember. But I started hearing a lot of Duke, I started — I'll tell you the truth though, I was in jazz mostly. Later on I'll probably remember some other rock stuff. I loved rock even at the beginning. I was never like, ooh, rock. And originally I loved Stan Kenton, and I said, "Aww this is great." And I had a great teacher in New Haven, Connecticut named Sonny Costanza who used to play in Clark Terry's big band. And he was a great teacher. He was more like a great trombonist who you sat next to him and you like, you learned a lot because he was just amazing. And he pushed me straight. And there was a college band out of Quinnipiac College, the Quinnipiac College Band it was called, it was like about 45 minutes from where I lived. So I used to go there. When I was being punished or stuff, and didn't have the car, my mother would drive me. And so we would play, like Clark Terry was a guest once, a lot of those, oh yeah, Si Zentner, who, yeah, that's right, and Kai Winding, I met all these guys.

MR: Quinnipiac had a festival every year.

AB: Yeah, they started having a festival too. Yeah. And there was also a jazz club in my home town of Fairfield, Connecticut, a guy named Bill Ratzenberger. The mouthpiece Jet Tone,

have all these guys. And he heard me with Quinnipiac. And notice how I'm not even answering that question.

MR: I forget what the question was, but —

AB: The music that inspired me, yeah.

MR: Yeah.

AB: But somewhere I know I was listening to rock. But anyway, he heard me play with the Quinnipiac Band and said, "Hey, Clark Terry's playing next week, why don't you come and sit in?" So we'd come to sit in with all these guys. I'd come and I'd sit in. I'll never forget the first time I was playing and they had a great alto player named Ed Graf who also had a music store and sold records and stuff, we used to go to downtown Bridgeport to look at records and buy them all the time. And then he actually taught at this high school, Notre Dame Boys, and I used to play in the big band there. And he was in it, Gene Bergmark was a great piano player, a great bass player, I can't remember his name, a great drummer. And I'd sit in. So like I remember the first time, I think it was like Clark and Eddie laid down a background riff for me. You know what that feels like, you feel like wow. I mean I had it even more blown up in my head, I was like wow I've really made it, they played a background riff while I was soloing. When I'm soloing I have no idea what I'm doing.

MR: No, but I had the same experience with Clark Terry.

AB: Oh yeah, oh man.

MR: He came here and played, and I'm thinking he just comes up with this little riff and I'm thinking to myself I could never have thought of that. It's so perfect.

AB: It's funny that I'm going to skip forward, for many years there was a great sax player named Haywood Henry, [inaudible] for Erskine Hawkins.

MR: Yeah, third —

AB: He actually used to sub in Duke's band sometimes when Harry wasn't there. But Haywood told me like the first time he ever did it, you know he went in there and was like what's going to happen, they're all like, this could be a drag. And Haywood got on the bandstand and he started playing and someone said in the back, you could hear someone say, "All right everything's going to be all right. So what was I telling the story about? I'm losing it. Oh, oh, the riff, the riff. So anyway, we used to do a lot of gigs. I have a seven piece group called The Dukes, I'll get you a CD and stuff. And sometimes when they couldn't afford the whole eight piece group we'd do like a quintet or a sextet, because I had a great front line of like Haywood and me and this great trumpet player, Irvin Stokes, probably like Richard Wyands playing piano, and guys like Earl May on bass, these things like that, so it's a great band. We're playing a wedding on a boat —

never try to fool them to think they're going to get top 40. And there was people who really wanted it. So three of us are up there, horn players, and we're playing, someone's taking a solo, we set riffs, so I set a few riffs. And so one time after Haywood heard a few of the riffs I was setting, he always gave me a ride home with his wife Mil. And he said, "Boy you sound real good, man. And you know those colored riffs."

MR: No kidding?

AB: You know you learned those colored riffs. He always liked to say things like that too, that just would make me laugh. Some stories he told over and over again, because he knew I loved them. He was amazing man.

MR: Was there any, the feeling of a white boy fitting in with some of these older black men?

AB: You know I was just so crazy in a way, I was just like wow. And when I got the gig with Ellington. I was a hippie. I weighed probably about 65 pounds, not like I do now, and my hair was way down here.

MR: Really?

AB: On the bus I was a mess. I was a hippie. But you know they had the white dinner jackets, I was fine on the bandstand. You would do a ponytail this way. They never judged me. You know, if they did they sure kept it quiet. We went to Ethiopia, we went to Haile Selassie's palace, and there were like, there was like Barrie Lee Hall, you know who he is, a great trumpet player. Barrie Lee Hall. He sat at the feet of Cootie Williams and learned how to play. He was at the totally into Woody Shaw and Freddy and he joined the Cootie taught him, just by being next to him. Anita Hall, who passed, was a great singer, and Rocky White, the drummer. They called us the Mod Squad. And they had to go out and dig up jackets for us to go to the palace.

MR: No kidding. You weren't ready for that.

AB: I'm a lot different now. I've learned, since I've been booking my band for years and stuff, but I was a hippie.

MR: Did Ellington hire you himself?

AB: Here's what — remember Jimmy Maxwell, the trumpet player?

MR: Oh yeah, Jimmy.

AB: He played with Benny Goodman. I know he played with Mercer. But I can't remember, but he was dear friends with Cootie. We were like, one time, right after Duke passed, he came out with the band and there was like this like two week engagement in Bermuda and they were flying people in. Like Ella was there and Billy Taylor, all kinds of people. So they were flying in and everything worked out. So Jimmy Maxwell played in some rehearsal bands that I was in, and we got to be really good friends. And he used to say, "Man you sound more like Tricky Sam Nanton, than Tricky Sam. And even at that time I

in small groups with him and stuff. So the band, Duke's band was playing at the Rainbow Grill from like Monday or Tuesday to Saturday. Sunday nights they didn't play. But that band was sax section, trumpet, and rhythm section. They used the same charts. And somehow, his music is so heavy that it's just worked. They know how to play it. Did you ever hear the album "The Unknown Sessions?"

MR: No.

AB: Oh find that. It's four horns. It's like alto — Harry and Johnny, alto and bari; Ray Nance, Lawrence Brown. That's a common combination. It's on CD now for sure. And like you know the alto is here and the baritone is here, and it still sounds like a sax section.

MR: Wow.

AB: That's right, you know the right tessitura, the right part of the instrument, and so anyway, I keep going on these tangents, so Jimmy — you don't mind, do you? —

MR: No, that's why we're here.

AB: I was going mouth him. So Mercer was managing the band at the time, called Jimmy and said, "We need a trombone player for two Sundays." And Jimmy recommended me. I got the call for that gig. I remember being, right around then I was out at my mom's house with someone else and I just pulled out a record I said, "This is who I'm playing with next week." I was like — and I remember calling people and the big advice I got, not from Jimmy, from someone else said, "Make sure you don't sit in someone's seat on the bus." And I go like, "Well how do I know?" So I get on the bus and I heard this booming voice, "You sit here, boy." That's where I sat forever since then. Third one on the right, that's my home. Chuck Connors in front of me, Russell Procope to the right. And so I had those two gigs, and I figured well, that'll be on my resume, two gigs with Duke Ellington. So on the second one, it was a big outdoor concert in Boston. I forgot where it was but a woman named Elma Lewis has this whole, I don't know if she's still around but she had this whole thing for the community all over the place. I think it was a free concert. A big outdoor thing. So we're setting up and Duke says, "You want to come out with us, you want to play with us." And then you know, he says, "Just come in my trailer afterwards." He had a trailer. And I was like — whoa. I though it was like two gigs. So I'm in the trailer and it's a little bigger than an average dressing room trailer for one. The place is packed with people. Food, caviar, ice cream, all kinds of drinks, booze, everything. He says, "Artie, just have a drink, have some food, I'll be right back." "Oh Duke," and Duke goes out to talk to this woman, and he comes back twenty minutes later and says, "So Artie, you want to come out and play with us?" "Oh yeah, man, I'd love to." He says, "Well let's talk about detai—" "Oh Duke, come here for a minute please, Duke." And when he heard the woman's voice he had to go like. It was like that for about 45 minutes.

to talk business here, but call me tomorrow or something." I was like, some friends of mine who lived in Boston, I was staying with them, I was like whoa, I was like blown away. Then I talked to him a day or two later and so I'm on the phone and he says, "Well how much do you want?" Oh, no, actually, we didn't even talk money. He just said, "Well we're leaving ten days from now, and then in a month we're going to Europe, we're going to Africa for about five or six weeks." I was like ohh, this is amazing. Then when we finally got on the road and there was room, he said, "Well how much do you want?" I'm like uh uh — how much do I have to pay.

MR: Yeah, right. Oh you mean I get paid too?

AB: So it was amazing. And you know Jimmy Maxwell, you know, my hero.

MR: Well did you make a weekly salary?

AB: Yeah it depended, night by night, a certain amount. I think it was about like 75 bucks, and this was like '73 you know, so a full week was like $450 or something like that, is that right? They took the hotel out of it, the hotels were like 15 dollars. So it was like nothing. The funny thing is though the way they paid — Paul Gonsalves probably ended up being the highest paid musician in all of history, because his bar bills — we always stayed at hotels that had restaurants and bars. And his bar bills were legend. And he'd always buy you drinks. I mean the guys were wonderful. When I first joined the band though, I had just started meditating. So for a month they ask you to not do anything that I would either get out of a bottle or get arrested for— was that a good way to put it? So I was pretty clean when I joined the band and we were playing at Mr. Kelly's, which is a Chicago club, for a couple of weeks, and then we were going off the Europe to play a sacred concert. This is the third one I was telling you about. And so I was practicing this little — I'm answering questions you haven't even asked yet, that's good. I'm practicing my recorder. Because I wasn't going to hang out at the bar, because I realized quick enough there was something better to do. But anyway so I'm practicing the recorder up there and then his valet, Jim Lowe, comes over and says, "Hey, the old man wants to see you, and bring that little flute." Because he didn't really like the metal flute so much, he wrote a little bit near the end, but he loved the recorder and he wrote a "Lord's Prayer" for me. And he kept saying — I remember on the day before the concert we're practicing and he says, "Here I finally got it for you." But anyway, after that I started hanging out at the bar and hanging out with these guys. It was amazing. I mean, so many stories.

MR: Did Duke copy his own music?

AB: He had a copyist.

MR: He had a copyist.

AB: And the copyist had to know his style — because he might just give you two staff lines

Tom Whaling did it for many years, Chuck Conners did it for a little bit and Joe Benjamin, the bass player.

MR: So they actually scored some of his — I mean he wouldn't write the whole score.

AB: He would, but he had a way to do it, really compact.

MR: I see.

AB: Oh all the notes were there.

MR: Oh, okay. And they had to sort them out.

AB: Even one night Duke had three trombones, one line with all three parts, but it was like — and we sight read it on a concert. And it went okay. You know it was some kind of piece, ahh, after he read Hailie Selassie, it was about the lion of Judah, or the name of the lion that met us at the airport, it was some messianic, or, I can't remember, my friend will remember, and he was writing this song about it. So we got through it and Duke said, "Ladies and gentlemen, I'd like you to meet three of the most courageous trombone players you'll ever meet."

MR: You know Grover Mitchell told me a story about when he was first on the band.

AB: He was with Duke?

MR: Yeah.

AB: I know he did Basie, I didn't know he did Duke.

MR: Yeah, he did. And he said the first night was unbelievable, and the second night they were playing some club and the guys were — they started and half the guys weren't on the stage and they just wandered up, one guy is eating a steak, and he just was like how does he put up with this kind of thing.

AB: He had a very low heart rate and nothing bothered him.

MR: Really.

AB: I mean I only saw him get a little angry once, but it was sort of an act. When did Grover play with him? Grover was a dear friend and I didn't know it.

MR: I'd have to look it up.

AB: Maybe — I wonder if it was that period in the fifties, in the early fifties where it was changing a fair amount, after Tricky Sam died, Lawrence Brown left for a while, and I'm going to check it out.

MR: Well you seem to not have any fear of stepping into any particular musical situation.

AB: Just a minute, I used to go, I remember when I was in high school with those doctors, and they'd go somewhere to this club and jam. I'd jump on stage, just sort of like earn while you learn, or I'm learning a tune, because I'd play a background or something like that. And I remember like a tune like in B flat might go into a D at the bridge or something like that. Okay, I'm just going to add a lot of sharps and see what happens. I just came up

MR: But what's the biggest — was there a big difference from going to Duke Ellington to Stevie Wonder.

AB: Stevie Wonder was first actually.

MR: Stevie Wonder was before Duke Ellington. Wow.

AB: Yeah. I was in Berklee School of Music in my fifth semester there. And everything started not making sense. There were too many rules. I told you, I was a rebel. You'd walk into some kind of composition class or something, and there were like twenty rules: you can't do this, you can't do this, can't do this, and it was like man, this is not for me anymore. Music is not about rules, it's about heart and soul and music. And so I left school. I had played with Stevie a couple of times when he was in town and he'd hire horn section and had a conductor, Gene Keefe, great guy. And he stayed on conducting when I joined the band for a while. And he was like one of these great supporters of me when I got the gig with Duke and stuff, he was like just thrilled, you know we stayed in touch for years. So when Stevie wanted to carry the whole thing instead of hiring horns, he liked the horns from Boston so he came to Boston and they hired horns. However, I didn't make all the gigs, there was this other trombone player, this young red-haired guy named Kenny, and they asked him to do the tour and I was like oh, man. So I went to the trumpet player they had hired and I said, "Look, you know, if you ever need it, I'd love to come on." And a couple of days later he calls me and said Kenny's mother wouldn't let him go on the road.

MR: All right, thanks mom.

AB: So and that was like a year and a half or so it went on. We went to South America and Europe, and it was so great. Talk about interviews, we had this one interview about Stevie. Stevie was just coming out of — actually I'll just skip to this first — Stevie was just coming out of the "Fingertips," "My Cherie Amour," and into the new stuff, I'm on the album called "Music of My Mind" have you ever heard of that? And that was the first time he produced the whole album. He played everything except for me and Buzzy Feiten played guitar and he had a solo on this thing called "Love Havin' You Around."[sings] So he produced the whole thing. He was playing everything. And it was so funky and so great. And there's a part where I have a solo and it's of course everything but the kitchen sink in there so it comes in and out. But oh yeah, so Stevie had a thing that he used to do — is that what I was talking about —

MR: In the interview.

AB: Yeah. When he was interviewed, the drummer and I and the bass player used to hang out a lot. And we said, "Ahh Stevie's going to goofland." Like the interviewer would ask him a question like you're doing, and he'd go on a tangent, but he'd go on a tangent and start

the planet can be — we can stop hunger and we only have to change the way the world is governed." And the guy said, "Where do you buy those clothes" or something. And we'd say, "Stevie's going to goofland.

MR: I see.

AB: Like you know, at least here we're trying to keep it in the context of music but he'd be way out there and you'd never remember what the question was.

MR: Right.

AB: Of course now I'm doing it.

MR: Yeah, right, what was our question.

AB: I'm just going to goofland.

MR: What did you gain from Berklee?

AB: Berklee was great. I mean I'll be honest, and this is not a criticism of Berklee, the best I got was the jam sessions at night and stuff, after school and stuff. I played with all — I mean I played really out to lunch, avante garde stuff, which I still like a lot of that because it's — like for me "Heart and Soul," if it's in there it's great. The form doesn't matter to me so much. I love like what we're doing up here with the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band. But and in the classes I was just starting to write music, I loved writing music, I loved writing songs and stuff. I had Phil Wilson, the trombone player who played with Woody Herman, and great teacher, great. I mean he taught great but he was also, probably even more than Sonny, like the kind of guy you stand next to and like you learn so much just playing with him. And a couple of people really benefit every year, I mean he picked on me. He decided that he was going to help me man. Before I even knew what this expression meant, like he would yell across the lobby of the school and he said, "Hey Art, man, when are you going to start playing with some balls?" And I didn't even know what it meant. Balls? I don't think I knew. And he was like that. And he got me a gig with Buddy Rich for like 2-1/2 weeks when one of the guys had to leave before the new guy came in. And he was great. And I had arranging class with him. I had a great arranging teacher named Bob Chestnut. And not a well known name but he really was brilliant to work with. There was a guy Dean Earl there, he used to play piano with Charlie Parker and he's on wire recordings with Charlie. So just the environment, it really got me into writing, I studied composition there. That was very helpful. So anyway but Phil has been a dear friend for years, and we don't talk for years and then we'll talk again. When I got the gig with Duke his reaction was like, "Son-of-a-bitch, I always wanted that gig, but I'm glad you got it, man." Like that. Because he got this bass player on the gig, Paul Concella was his name, in the late 60s, who really could write like Duke who really had a sense of that, not exactly, but, you know. But that's the school was like

how I was going to do it, you know, so I just like I fell into that Stevie Wonder gig. And the funny thing is I went from one to another and the cost of living was nothing like it is now. God, like I don't know how people do it now. I mean you've certainly got to make a lot of money going out of school. So I went to New York, and the hardest times were when some lean times hit, like in the early 90s or something, where I never did the thing where I'd do other gigs to figure out how to do it. I remember once I had a girlfriend and she was doing proofreading. And she said, "You know you could do proofreading, or do it at night, and you don't have to be concerned about someone seeing you do something else." So I thought yeah, I've got to do something that gets me through the slow period. So it was a two part course in proofreading. So I went to take the first part. After that I got so busy I never took the second. Once I saw that I said okay I'm going to do whatever I have to do to make things work.

MR: So you've never had any long term, non-music gigs?

AB: No. When I came home from college I worked in a deli or something, but I quit that.

MR: Did your parents, like were they supportive?

AB: Do they worry and do they still worry? My father always used to say to me, "When are you going to go back to school?" "When are you going to get a haircut." Right? Then I started playing with Duke Ellington and he never really said too much like that. It was some years after that when I was back in New York. I was really into math and I went as far as calculus in high school and I really loved it. I love using that part of my mind. So about ten years later I decided to take a class at the New School in calculus again to see if I could do it. And it was a hundred bucks, without credit, three hundred for the credit. I never got a degree. So I called my father and I said, "What do you think, do you think I should go for the credit?" And he says, "What do you need credit for?"

MR: Whoa. He came around. Yeah. Well your weekly — a week for you, I can imagine every day is like a little different. Right.

AB: It's totally different, totally different. Like I book my own band, so when I have time to do that I spend as much as I can. Then I'll have — I mean this Tuesday a friend of mine does a cartoon for kids called "The Backyardigans," you ever hear of this?

MR: No.

AB: It's on Nickelodeon. I used to do another one called "Rocko's Modern Life." And I love playing that, cartoons. So this guy, so we'll be there probably a good part of the day on Tuesday. Tuesday night I have a rehearsal for a big band for the one I was telling you about at this Quaker School and we're going to do a concert for them on Thursday afternoon. And it's just more stuff coming up. I mean you know I'm going to England. Oh, the band is going for about three days to a jazz festival. Then I'm going over as a

left, but Buster Cooper, the great trombone player in the sixties, he and I and this great bass player from then, John Lamb. They had a great—

MR: You say hi for us. I've interviewed those guys.

AB: Oh, great, great.

MR: Yeah.

AB: Because we did something similar to this in California about four years ago. They had probably all the alumni left that they could find except for Clark couldn't make it. And you remember Uhura from Star Trek? Do you know she sang with Duke?

MR: No. I didn't know that.

AB: Yeah. They couldn't find her somehow. And we did performances which was great, and then we all did the history stuff.

MR: I've heard something about the Ellington Society here, that they're very, they don't like to hear anything bad about Duke Ellington. They get like —

AB: You talking about the one in New York City?

MR: Yeah.

AB: Yeah it's funny. I'm not strict about that myself, but I just think, I don't even know why it has to come out. Yeah, he probably stole from Billy Strayhorn, you know? Who knows? You know what I mean?

MR: Well didn't he sort of listen to what people were playing too and take little pieces of what their warm-ups were?

AB: Yeah. Now I don't know if this actually happened. But check out this possible scenario. (Sorry, Duke.) Where they're playing "Rose Room" and Johnny Hodges has an idea for a background lick [scats]. I like that. It could have been. I mean the thing is beautiful music came out into the world.

MR: Right.

AB: You know, and people got happy. They got elevated. The ones that have to research and find out what the scoundrel aspect of a person is, you know —

MR: Is that going to make you feel better to know that?

AB: Yeah. And some people thrive on this stuff. I mean I don't like defend it. He was a human being. And was he brilliant, was he a genius, yes. Did he possibly do something a little off-handed? Could be. Do I care? No.

MR: Right.

AB: Except when it's a cool story or something. I just don't think it's important, you know. I mean you can find dirty laundry on everybody. You and me even.

MR: So you play the conch shell also?

AB: Yes. Not as — that's just as like Steve Turre does, he studies it like crazy. But I have

he just kind of like — what's the word I'm looking for when you want to like sanctify a space before you do a deep piece or something you know. Go to the four corners and things like that. I love playing at those. I'll see if I can get another copy of it. This woman, a great composer, she teaches — no she just retired — up at Poughkeepsie, oh I'm spacing, at a girl's school there, a woman's school. It's a good school. And what's the big school in Poughkeepsie, it used to be all women.

MR: Not St. — I don't know.

AB: Anyway, it's a very well known school. Anyway, she taught there, a wonderful woman from New Zealand. So she wrote a piece for me to play and a percussionist, Scott Robinson is his name — not the sax player. And we brought all our stuff: conch shells, flutes, whistles, trombones, didgeridoo and all kinds of stuff. And he played all the percussion and conch. So we started doing some stuff, and the piece was called, what is the series where you add one: one plus two is three, it's a Fibonacci series.

MR: The what series?

AB: The Fibonacci series. It's a natural mathematical series that occurs in nature. And the nautilus, the shell, it increases mostly I believe by the Fibonacci series. So she kind of drew this diagram of going into the shell I think it was, the scope, the width and breadth got bigger and we're improving based on this. And I mean in music there are a lot of interesting ways to get into a free improvisation with some guidelines like that. And I'm not saying that we don't pay it mind, I'm not saying that we say I've got to accept that we say okay I've got to exactly do this, but it's like we ingest the idea and what comes out comes out. But someone clearly has an idea how you do it so we played all the way into the center. Oh it starts big and gets small, that's right, that's what happens. And then we took a break and then we took it back in a packed house. And so within there, the two of us were playing conches together, and they overlapped. Like if you'd put your hand in it, it makes it go up. It goes flat when you put your hand in it. So we would meet — it's fairly close when we met, the different tones you know you have. You know like [scats] was so pronounced in the room that she got this idea so she wrote this piece and for oh God like three percussionists and four didgeridoos but they played different things at different times. Like two of us played trombone at different times, using the natural overtone series like the A flat in first position and high A flat, because on a trombone it's flat. So like on a trumpet if you're playing G concert here and you want to play the octave, which is A on the horn, on trombone you could play it in second, you know. But it's a flat partial, you pull it up to make it tempered. But on the trumpet, you know, like if you played that note it would be flat. That is the naturally occurring seventh, you know, lowered seventh degree on the scale, so if you wrote like that in mind, it was a great

us do these things where we come together, stay together, pass each other and come down like that, you know it does this for a while. It's this incantation — that's another word I was looking for. And it's amazing. It sets up this piece and it's an oboe player and a contrabass clarinet player and it's called "One Thousand Year Dreaming," I'll see, I might have a few extras. It's a very meditative piece. And we used to do performances and she'd show slides from the Lascaux caves in France, you know, the drawings in there. I remember one of the first times we did it in New York we did a run through for a sound check and it's just gets you so high. And at the end she makes the sound of a Maori, you know, from New Zealand, you know [scats] but I can't do it. You know like.

MR: Oh yeah, Ululating.

AB: Yeah. Do it at the end of the piece, to finish the piece. So it's like she did that for me once on the streets of New York. I mean she's another person, she does these amazing things and it's totally like, what's Art Baron doing in there, but it's like, it's got such a heart and soul. It's not like let's do something far out and we'll call it new music. And that's what's great about it. And that's why I've had this really great career that I've had to play with. You know I used to worry like if someone, like that Harlem Blues and Jazz or something like that, that we'd play something avante garde or something like that, oh what's he doing. And it even happened once with us, we played with this guy George Gruntz who has a big band from Switzerland. We were playing some out stuff. Like this piano player I play with, [inaudible] I used to play with Oliver Jackson Jr., do you know him?

MR: The drummer?

AB: The drummer, yeah, he was a great friend. And he was cool about all kinds of things. And he worked with George Wein and the Newport All Stars, like he was the road manager. And he was just this great guy. So he was in Europe and he had played on the same stage with some group like, who was that saxophone quartet, you know, the very modern one.

MR: Hamiet Bluiett —

AB: Hamiet Bluiett — anyway — or maybe it was Lester Bowie or something like that.

MR: Oh like the Chicago, the AACM.

AB: Exactly, right. And I loved that stuff. And I said, "Ollie, man, that's great, you play with those guys, and he only did two sections of the concert. And how'd they sound?" And he said, "Oh man it was great," he said, "it was like a fire at the zoo."

MR: That's a good description.

AB: I loved that. I mean I always felt that music, you know, you could be fooled sometimes but I always felt people that were serious about it and were really making music, or the

of playing free music. It just sort of coming from a place where you had a disciplined amount, but it was so funny, a fire at the zoo, you know that sound.

MR: Didn't you recently do something with Bruce Springsteen also?

AB: That was another one of those gigs like out of the blue. So you don't sit around thinking oh man I wish I had a gig with Bruce Springsteen because you know he says his E Street Band and he has regular horns. Like the guys who are on Conan O'Brien, Mark Pender and La Bamba the trombone player, Richie, they play with him a lot. Well some friends of mine had been playing with him for years. On his birthdays they would play his parties, called the Golfing Playboys, and like did Zydeco and stuff like that and the drummer's, a great drummer, could play the rub board and all kinds of beats, and named Larry Eagle. So they'd been doing this for years, and then Bruce got called to do some numbers on a CD to — what's the word I'm looking for — to just to honor Pete Seeger. And so he used that band. He recorded that band. Like "We Shall Overcome," and something, he recorded a bunch with them. I think "We Shall Overcome" ended up on the CD. And after recording them, he recorded them again and it was a many year project. And then he started really getting into the idea of finishing the CD, whether he put it out or not. So when he was finishing it, I mean everything was live with these people. And many things happened that I don't know exactly. And then he said, "I want to put a tuba in here and some pennywhistle, because he was doing some Irish stuff too. So they were saying, "You guys know a good tuba player for this?" and they gave them some names, and then the pennywhistle, and the drummer said, "Wait a minute, I've got a friend who plays both. The funny thing is I'd only played trombone with him, but I think he remembered seeing it in my car. But he said he knew I played them well. So I got the call just to do one recording on top of this wonderful — you know usually — you know, you're a sax player, did you ever do a thing where you're overdubbing on a track?

MR: Um hum.

AB: You know and sometimes it's fun and sometimes like where's the beat. Plus playing tuba, it's like a bass thing. So if it's not in there, and I really had to hear what the bass player was doing. It was so easy. I'm in a recording studio, they sent a limo to my house in New York to go to South Jersey to Rumson where one of his houses was where he had a recording studio there. So they're doing this stuff and I'm listening to all this music. They're doing a little editing before I come in. And I'm like sitting there thinking what is this going to be like and I hadn't met Bruce yet, I don't think so, I think I met the engineer, a really great guy, Toby. And I'm thinking what's this going to be like. So I'm warming up. I had two tubas with me, I had a small E flat and a bigger B flat. And I've got all these whistles with me with the different keys. And I want to make sure, you

could be like oh I'm playing with so-and so, you know, like that. And so it took a while for him to get ready. They keep the limo there, they're paying for the limo, and I'm talking about a really nice limo. "Would you like a drink or something?" Stuff like that. And so I'm listening to them do the music and they're doing a little editing they had to finish, and it was all stuff I knew from playing in that jug band.

MR: Oh wow.

AB: So I go wow, this is going to be great. Even later on I said, "Hey, you want to hear the jug too?" So he had me come in and he just wanted the tuba in some spots, and it was funny, like I'm a really good reader, and he had a — not a super hard whistle part, but just give me some time to learn it. Often I'll say like give me a few minutes and let me write it down, so take after take I'll know exactly what the notes are supposed to be instead of trying to remember. But we didn't do it that way. But the whistle stuff went fine, the tuba went fine. He was cool, man, he was great man, and like in the middle of the session the phone rings and they said, "Hey Bruce, it's Patti," you know, his wife. "Are you going to pick up the kids at school today?" And he was great. And he shook my hand. And it's funny, you know the trombone is my major instrument, and so I know when I'm playing well on trombone and when it's being rolled to tape or to the hard drive, but you know you don't know a hundred percent sure. We ended up using the smaller tuba and a bunch of whistles, and I thought I did okay but then again you never know. You never know if someone's going to go like okay it was a mistake, we shouldn't have booked it. Or you never know, oh we really loved it. You never know what's happening. So I got a call about ten days later, he we want to do another session. So I guess he liked me.

MR: Good, good.

AB: So I went down there and during the session this other guy was there, George, one of the managers. And someone told me, he says, "We're thinking about maybe doing a couple of gigs with this band." When I first went in there they didn't even know if they were going to release this. It became "The Seeger Sessions" the record that came out.

MR: It was on television, wasn't it?

AB: Yeah.

MR: Yeah I remember seeing that with all those instruments.

AB: Oh it was great. The people absolutely loved it. And so I ended up on the road with him. Oh I got private airplanes. You know you don't even have to go through the airport, you go through this little building at the edge, or a private airport. You get a little bit of security at the base of the plane. But his security was tougher than anyone else's. You know like I could bring a family member on the bus but I couldn't bring a girlfriend or

MR: Oh. I see.

AB: If it was someone that you didn't know from birth, it was okay, I mean if you did know. So we went all over. Great guy. He would arrange stuff in his — you know if he'd put out an arrangement, you know, nothing was written down. So we had six weeks of rehearsals that were paid well so if you had a gig — it was done in the day too so you could work at night. They sent the limo every day to pick us up.

MR: Good Lord.

AB: I got so spoiled. And these airplanes man, like you'd go on and it was like you know just so nice and just so easy. You'd have one for a couple of weeks sometimes and you'd buy things on the road, you'd just schlep them on and off the plane and just leave them there.

MR: No one told you, be careful what seat you sit on in the airplane, right?

AB: Oh, actually they did.

MR: Did they really?

AB: They did. Front five. Stay away from those.

MR: No kidding? Some things never change, you know?

AB: Boy, don't sit here.

MR: On the way up we were talking a little bit about jazz education, and all the students that are doing it nowadays.

AB: Well I've really gotten into that a lot.

MR: Have you?

AB: I've never worked to get the work but I'm getting ready to do that now. You know I've got some management people I'm starting to work with. But I told you I had started meditating when I started working with Duke. And that was a whole kind of path, I didn't even know it was connected with music. Then I ended up taking all kinds of workshops and visualization, manifestation, yoga, Tai Chi. You know David Darling by any chance?

MR: The cellist? Yeah.

AB: He had a great thing that I used to sit in. I took some classes with him called "Music for People," about just teaching groups of people from a concert violinist to someone who never did music in their lives, to making good music together. And it was brilliant. And he invited me to come to this thing he did, it was in '86, like a week-long thing in the summer where I would just hang out and be part of it. And so I grew, both fields started coming together, seeing how you could help teach someone. And the first time I really realized this was a guy's coming into my house for lessons. And I've been contemplating this. I sat next to Cootie Williams for three years. And he was a good friend. And how he played [scats] laid back so far, and it just told so much and just sound, not a lot of notes, but the sound. So I thought about this. How do you give someone the experience of

and this idea flashes in my head to have him just walking through cheese. Because I was thinking about this thing. There's a resistance. You know when you play music, like to learn jazz violin you really have to learn about what it's like to play a horn. Because things come too easy. You know people that can play really well, you know it's harder to learn to swing. And I think about like Ellington's band, they could really lay back, but the rhythm section stayed right there — the difference between that and a band that's just dragging. So there's this like tension between it. So I would have them walk through cheeses like you'd have to walk. I mean like visualize, my apartment is like Swiss cheese. And every movement is like this. And I'm talking about like an hour and a half or an hour fifteen minutes like this, and I would teach them a song after they got acclimated to this idea. And I said, "When you sing back to me," and mind you I'd never done this before.

MR: You're making it up as you go along, yeah.

AB: Yeah, and I'll be honest. I mean it's not that I don't take credit but through meditation and stuff like this, things just come through and you can't — I think you lose it when you say oh isn't it great what I came up with. But it came through, and I take credit for being the vessel for it. So basically he comes through in the house and I sing a song called "Wanderlust," do you know this? An old blues by Duke. [scats]. You know it's really laid back blues. And I would teach it phrase by phrase, and have them sing it. But then you can't get the sound. [scats]. I ended up doing this with groups of like 40 people. And other ideas have come. So they'll do that to the point where they can sing that like an old blues band, and I say okay, now get the horn. But you know what always happens? They forget they're in cheese. They walk around, gee, you can't walk that fast in cheese. That's why I always let those lessons go longer because it takes — and they do the same thing, sing that thing then play it on the horn, and then we move, after all that, you know, we move to the piano and sing it, and I'll play the chords, and then improvise. Usually when they start improvising they go back to just how they sounded before, maybe a little better.

MR: A little better, wow.

AB: I mean the first two sound like some old black man doing his blues. And you can see in their faces they're blown away. So I mean early on, it's been twenty years probably, since that started. I saw there is a way to really find ways to get the sound out. Like I sing in the car [scats] you can learn that. And there's nothing wrong with making new language. But finding your inner voice. So it's really been a blessing and a gift to me. Like I go into a room and I've been doing a lot of stuff at Lincoln Center, not the Jazz at Lincoln Center but they have visitor services like where a big band will come from Chicago and they'll tour Lincoln Center and then have a workshop with me and their

techniques. I mean and it's just about getting them to get a sound. I remember one time I was at UVA uh, the Commonwealth, with Doug Richards, a great teacher down there, he had me there for a week. And there was this lead trumpet player, Nick, he had the most beautiful sound. But there was nothing inside the sound, it was just beautiful. Physically you learn how to do it. And just ideas would come to me, like these movement ideas and stuff, leaning the stomach against the hand, and all kinds of stuff. So a couple of times, he hit a note that was him, and you could feel it in the room and it was like wow. And that sound just like blew up. I mean I'm not freaking out but I'm going like wow. It took me a long time to really believe, sort of like you remember "The Music Man?" The Think System?

MR: Yeah, yeah.

AB: It's really similar to that. I mean it's an internal thing. Because you can't sit next to Cootie Williams for six or seven nights a week for a year, now, you know you can't. So I feel really blessed.

MR: Yeah. You got on the tail end of that.

AB: I love going around doing this. I mean when I did that one in Chicago, the kids, first of all the teachers always say like — well I always ask them what they want to do. They say, "Well we'd like to work on precision" and things like that. One time with a band from Australia, the precision was mind-boggling. And afterwards he said, "We need to work on precision a little bit."

MR: Really?

AB: I said, "Would you mind if I go in a little different direction?" Because generally when I work with a big band, within ten minutes the stands are away, the music's away, we just do stuff up, you know, movement and stuff. But the first thing I like to do is like I'll have the band, the leader will play a couple of pieces so I can hear some of the soloists, you know, hear how they play together. And then I'll say, "Okay, you guys sound good." And they do, they work hard and they're a little nervous but I mean okay. I say, "Now I want you to play the song again but no matter what I do keep playing. If it makes you laugh, try not to laugh, just keep playing. So they start playing and I go around and I'll go over and take the lead alto player's music and throw it on the floor, and do that with a few other players and stuff and just like sort of turn the music around. And they're like hamina-hamina. So then we'll do it for a while and then we'll stop. And I'll say, "Well what was that experience like?" Because they're married to the music you know.

MR: Yeah, yeah.

AB: And I hold up the paper and I say, "What was it like?" I say, "See this paper? See all these black dots and lines? What was invented first, music or paper?"

MR: Especially the drummers, who are like, you know, they can't get their head out of the paper.

AB: Oh yeah and I say man, "Don't play any of the licks with the horns. Just give me time. Please." Why do they write the licks in it?

MR: Really. I know. I'm trying to remember who else said that that I interviewed, they said that about the Basie band, that that's why they swung so much because the drummers didn't have to nail everything.

AB: Yeah and if you nail something, great. You know like sometimes it's like that's — now you might have a great drummer that does that. But don't try to synthesize that and put it on the drum part and say every drummer has to do that now.

MR: Right.

AB: When you know it, when you've played it for two years without music, then you've got it. So they realize it's many, many years, since man existed they were making music I'm sure. I was telling, cavemen, they were making "rock" music then. And so they start getting it. You do all these things and like they start just really, and sometimes I'll like set up — oh this last one was so beautiful — just when I happened to be in the room, I'll set up like a tenor, a bari — maybe two tenors, a bari and a trombone over here. I got them into this little group [scats] something like that. And then I'd give trumpets here, this, and make it all go together. And I'd have a soloist, like a lead alto player, this young girl, and I put her on a chair and I said, "Can you stand up? Stand up on this chair." And she's blowing like this. And those guys setting up this basic rhythm, they're starting to do steps. And this is all, because they had no idea what it was going to be, they're feeling the groove. And sometimes I don't even have the drums play but I did this time. And it's like afterwards, you know, it's so intimate. When you've got your eye on that paper, man, it's not very intimate. And the thing is like, classical music, forget it. I've actually, you know Ray Anderson, the trombone player, he teaches out at the State University at Stonybrook. And once in a while I'll go sub for him when he's on the road or something. And I mean he's a dear friend. His daughter is my Goddaughter, we've been buddies forever, a phenomenal player. I don't know if you've heard his stuff. So anyway, so he's got a graduate group of classical musicians, two pianists, I think a bassoon player, a flute player and maybe percussion. Just learning improvisation, not necessarily jazz. But just a group improvisation. And they are so stuck on the paper. But they opened up, they were so beautiful you know. He has his techniques. Like he told me the first thing he had them do was, "Play as ugly as you can, real loud and ugly. Go guess what you think this should be." He is great. And so I would do my stuff with them, you know get them just to breathe and make a sound, and then sometimes it goes crazy. I remember working with

at a high school in New Jersey. And I couldn't get her at first to just like play without the music without going to something that she hadn't memorized. So now this was actually before the cheese or anything. And I said, "Come on let's sit on the floor." We sat on the floor with the piano behind us, and just put one hand up there and hit one note, and act like you've never heard a piano in your life, it would be just like a baby hearing the first note. Bing. And after a half hour of that she just started opening up.

MR: That's cool.

AB: Whether they're going to be an improviser or not.

MR: Right, right, right, that's right.

AB: Music is not paper. Paper is not music. You know what the old guys used to say to me? This is a guide. And I thought ah these old guys are talking such trash, I don't know if they really mean this is a guide. And I finally got it one day, years later, like playing with Duke or something, when I had most of the book memorized that we played. It's a guide. The guys in the band are playing. I remember when I first got in the band like I'm looking at this and they're playing that rhythm wrong.

MR: Yeah, right.

AB: That's off of four, they're practically on one, I should tell them.

MR: Don't do that, no, no, I don't think you're going to tell Cootie.

AB: I realized man, as you develop, that off of four they wanted to hang a little longer. So I realized it's a guide. Now today's arrangers would say, you know you come and see the band a year later, "Uh fellas, that's off of four." And Duke's music is like this. Other than the staff and the notes, that was it. No forte piano, sforzando, boom, boom. Once in a while a phrase marked, once in a while. But it was a guide. All of a sudden I got it. Here's a man who had an idea of how to put some notes together to play this song. And now arrangers think they're Gods. And I mean don't even ask them if they meant that. Even if it's a mistake in the copying. No, don't ask them. "Uh I meant that note, that's what it is." And even when kids are learning to arrange I tell them, I say, "Look, live the music, dance with it, hold the paper in your hand, dance around. Like I haven't gotten a computer and software yet, but I know I don't want to write this way. I want to write with a score in my hand. You know what does it feel like? Like Roswell, is this real? And then go to the computer. It's about life, it's about air. So the other thing, they say the horn is an extension of yourself. You know I'm like 60 here, yeah, yeah, whatever, so I'm an old man, give me another beer man or something. I mean I wasn't like that but you know it didn't make any sense to me. Like it was a seed, it was years later, I started seeing my playing change and ultimately, I don't really play jazz, I just make my sound and play music. You know if someone wants to say this is what he is doing that's okay. And it's

name is Bessie. It's like my hand fits in that. It's like another arm. It's like another part of me that can speak. And you know these old guys that did it, that's how they lived. Yeah certainly there were guys, you know, but guys that could play, you know Paul Gonsalves could do that? He loved playing ballads. I haven't given you a chance to ask questions.

MR: No this has been great. But you know what, we're going to have to do part two sometime though.

AB: Okay, is it time?

MR: Because we're going to have to get over to our engagement.

AB: I'll tell you a real quick thing though. At the end of the dance, they're tearing the band down, and he's going around to the tables and playing the ballad, like "Ramona," I don't even remember how that goes. And he just loved playing ballads. He was just a beautiful soul. He could play all that crazy stuff and swing real hard and you know those notes, and he used to play guitar first. But his stuff about, he loved playing ballads, and he had such a heart. It wasn't a soloist thing about it, you know there aren't many guys that can play those kind of notes and all that stuff, and it's just coming out of his heart. A lot of people, from that era they did though, from that era, it wasn't just about playing a lot of notes. You know if you played a lot, you'd better have feeling behind it. So then when you synthesize that you bring it to the schools — and this is no criticism to the schools — because it's not easy. I feel like I'm very fortunate that I've had these ideas, they're something else, other than just synthesizing those elements, there's something a lot deeper.

MR: Right.

AB: Why music you choose to begin with.

MR: That was a really very interesting outlook and I appreciate your time today. I wish I could bottle some of that stuff you have.

AB: I'm also trying to figure it out. Like I say, there's a certain current, the way things are going on in the world, you don't stand on a hill and say, "Wait a minute you're all wrong." There's a momentum from the last twenty or thirty years going a certain way. You just try to do what you can instead of looking at something that is opposition or something, just going to see what you can make right. That's just my idea of it, you know, based on all those older cats that were my mentors. There's a beauty in the music and it's not just about winning the cutting contest, it's about — like Tony Joseph's parents that were in — these guys were like musical parents when I was in high school. There they are last night at the concert. And they know it. And it's their life. And she says, "You know my back is bad when I listen to the music I forget all about it." The joke we say is like that a guy is in the audience and he says "you know my wife left me, my

kids hate me, my dog bit me and I lost my job, but this concert man, you guys just made me feel so good."

MR: All right. Well, well said. Thank you for your time.

AB: Nice talking to you.